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EXPECTING EXCELLENCE IN EDUCATION: WHEN CONTENT CONDITIONS CLASS CONSCIOUSNESS

Abstract

This article examines the tentacles between white supremacy, settler colonialism, and anti-Indian racism through the lens of "utopian ideologies" (Mohawk) and "cartographies of refusal" (Simpson). The paper is the result of the author's close collaboration with contemporary Haudenosaunee communities and living and working on the ancestral lands of the Onondaga Nation. Special attention is paid to how course design, visual art, and Indigenous values can help students understand how the legacies of white supremacy, settler colonialism, and anti-Indian racism continue to affect prevailing legal, political, religious, and media institutions in the United States of America.

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Introduction

When Dr. Philip Arnold, Dr. Adam Brett, and Sandy Bigtree reached out to me with the request that I put together a panel for their upcoming "The Religious Origins of White Supremacy: Doctrine of Christian Discovery" conference I was excited yet apprehensive, eager yet trepidatious. On one hand it felt wonderful to be invited back to Syracuse University and to the Hall of Languages, where I had earned my M.A., M.Phil. and Ph.D. in religion, but on the other hand returning to my alma mater forced me to remember a barrage of unpleasant memories. At times, during graduate school, I was impatient with my peers, insolent with my professors, and immature with my students. As a result of these inadequacies, I was unpopular with my peers and professors, and it took me far too long to finish my dissertation project. Once during a conversation over vegan pancakes Jonathan Boyarin shared with me that he had been a "terrible graduate student". It was a relief when such a well-known and respected scholar shared that with me, and it continues to give me strength today. But Phil never quit on me nor did my accomplices on the Onondaga Nation – and for that I am forever grateful and forever in their debt.

Teaching at SUNY Oswego for the last six years has been the most rewarding experience of my professional career. As the Director of Native American Studies I have been able to grow the program ten-fold from where it was before I took over, host numerous Haudenosaunee leaders (Chief Jesse Jacobs, Shawna Booth) for in class workshops and a variety of Native American artists and activists (Chelsea Maldonado, Martha Redbone, Leanne Betasamosake Simpson, Sandra Laronde, Katsitsionni Fox, Caleb Abrams) for campus wide events. Additionally, in 2024 I was honored to earn the "President's Award in Teaching Excellence" and serve as part of the initial cohort of the SUNY Fellowship in Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion. I have thrived at SUNY Oswego, and it is due in no small part to a small group of supportive colleagues whose vision and encouragement, mentorship and friendship have helped me go from "visiting" to "assistant" professor. As a group we are religiously/ethnically/racially diverse, we come from a variety of different academic disciplines across the University, and we have vastly different libraries and pedagogical approaches to teaching. Nevertheless, we are united through our repudiation of white supremacy, our rejection of settler colonialism, and our refutation of institutional racism. Dr. Celinet Duran-Jimenez (Assistant Professor, Criminal Justice), Dr. Roberta Hurtado (Associate Professor of English and Director of Latina/o and Latin American Studies), and Dr. Ritu Radhakrishnan (Associate Professor and Chair of Curriculum and Instruction) are three remarkable scholars whom I am indebted to for their benevolence and grace, guidance and generosity, cooperation and collaboration. Henceforth, when Phil, Adam, and Sandy asked me to put together a panel for their conference I knew exactly who to ask to join me…(my friends and colleagues) Dr. Duran-Jimenez, Dr. Hurtado, and Dr. Radhakrishnan.

I chose to title the panel "Pupils in the Professed Land: Confronting White Supremacy Across the Disciplines" as a play on keynote speaker Steve Newcomb's famous book *Pagans in the Promised Land: Decoding the Doctrine of Christian Discovery* and to ensure that each one of us could equally participate in the panel even though I am the only one of the four of us with a concentration in Native American and Indigenous Studies. Our panel was based on

responding to three primary questions: *1) What is your area of expertise, and can you explain the relationship between your research/teaching/creative interests and white supremacy? 2) What specific authors and artists, texts and media, do you rely on to engage students, faculty, and staff with the intersections between white supremacy, (anti-Indian) racism, and settler colonialism? 3) Have you ever caught yourself internalizing or reproducing white supremacy in your teaching, curriculum design, or pedagogy...how did you course correct?* The panel discussion was exciting and thought provoking. We were playful yet professional, improvisational yet intellectual, we gave one another space yet built on each other's responses, we listened instead of waiting to talk then afterwards we went out for Mexican food to celebrate a successful platica. In the pages that follow I will expand on my responses to the aforementioned prompts while providing insights into why I chose these particular prompts for this particular group.

Prompt #1: *What is your area of expertise, and can you explain the relationship between your research/teaching/creative interests and white supremacy?*

For the last twenty years I have been actively involved in cultivating relationships of exchange with contemporary Haudenosaunee peoples – particularly the Onondaga Nation. Working at the Onondaga Nation School exposed me to a new and subversive underbelly of American political and religious life. Working on sovereign Native land also provided valuable on the ground experience in Onondaga language and Haudenosaunee culture - food, humor, lacrosse, art, ceremony, government and education. Throughout my years working at Onondaga, I used comparison as the backdrop for my experiences collaborating with Native peoples as well as the methodological backbone for my dissertation project. The bonds I formed with my friends, collaborators, and accomplices entered me (and my family) into relationships of exchange, gratitude, and reciprocity with the Onondaga community which we continue to cultivate for the longevity of my career. According to Robin Kimmerer,

> The moral covenant of reciprocity calls us to honor our responsibilities for all we have been given, for all that we have taken…Gifts of the mind, hands, heart, voice, and vision all offered up on behalf of the earth. Whatever our gift, we are called to give it to and to dance for the renewal of the world.[1]

As an Assistant Professor of Anthropology and the Director of Native American Studies at SUNY Oswego who lives in the sprawling hills of central New York I have taken and continue to take A LOT from the community at Onondaga but it is my duty and my responsibility to always ensure that I am giving back/offering my gifts (through collaboration, teaching, publishing, leading workshops, centering Indigenous voices and values on campus) more than I take. My dissertation project, *Brothers in Blood: the Significance of Land and Loss in the Creation of Jewish and Native American Ethnic and Religious Identity*, represented an educational interface between Syracuse University and the Onondaga Nation School as much as it proposes a historical and theological interface between American Jews and American Indians. I argue that while the historical maintenance of a social-religious identity, outside a theological context, has caused patterns of Jewish and Native American identity creation to overlap and intersect the incongruities in the lived experiences of Jews in the United States and Natives in the United States arise from competing Jewish, Christian, and Native American orientations to religion, land, and community. Through the prisms of blood, land, genocide, and theology my dissertation research examined the interfaces between American Jews and American Indians as they converge and coalesce around patterns of settler colonialism, white supremacy, anti-

[1] Robin Kimmerer: *Braiding Sweetgrass: Indigenous Wisdom, Scientific Knowledge and the Teachings of Plants* (Minneapolis: Milkweed Editions, 2013), 378.

Indian racism, and anti-Semitism. Furthermore, I illustrate how these intersections can serve as a nexus for looking at the formation of race and ethnicity in the United States. White supremacy is key to understanding the racialization and oppression of both Jewish and Native American communities.

Famed Seneca scholar John Mohawk espouses an exquisite argument regarding the creation and continuation of white supremacy in Western society. In order to process and explain the ebbs and flows of white supremacy in Western society, Mohawk introduces the concept of "utopian ideologies." "Ideology" is a significant category for Mohawk, because "after the movements have altered or lost their energy, the ideologies may persist, preserved in the memory of culture in an honored position and capable of reemerging at a later time."[2] White supremacy is one of those ideologies that has managed to survive, preserved in the memory of American culture, and capable of reemerging in response to political, social, and economic change.

According to Mohawk, all "utopian ideologies" share several interrelated characteristics: first, "the group expects that their utopian story will culminate in the production of a perfect world," and second "the utopia does not actually arrive; it is always in the future."[3] Additionally, the "notion of progress" and "chosen people" is inherent to "true utopian thought."[4] While most "utopian ideologies" have not been embraced by mainstream society, the few that have become popularized have "provided background and context for some of the culture's defining moments."[5] Mohawk identifies the Nazi "third reich" and the "Christian Kingdom of God" as "pursuits of the cultural idea" that have had a profound effect on Western civilization and whose ideologies have become ingrained and preserved in Western society. By arguing that the German genocide and the American genocide were byproducts of "utopian social movements," Mohawk paints the trauma (historical, religious, cultural) of the German genocide in the exact same light as the trauma of the American genocide. These two acts of terror, separated by hundreds of years and thousands of miles, are comparable because the "utopian ideologies" governing their justifications shifted world events and lead to major geopolitical transformations.

White Supremacy and Settler Colonialism, anti-Semitism and anti-Indian racism are the byproducts of "utopian" movements but they are not endemic to Christianity/Christian theology. One side effect of "Western Utopianism" is that "people caught up in such movements tend to be intolerant of others" who are not part of the "projected destiny."[6] This kind of intolerance and ostracism can lead to the "denial of rights, including the right to live, to hold property, to vote, or to hold professional licenses" of non-believers."[7] According to Mohawk, the "scornful indifference" of the "unbelieving" and "unentitled" can manifest as "racism" and "ethnocentrism" as well as "crimes against humanity including systematic acts of genocide." As a result of their liminal status as non-believers, Jews in Europe and *onk'we'honwe* in America were subjected to the full force of racism, ethnocentrism, and

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[2] John Mohawk: *Utopian Legacies: A History of Conquest and Oppression in the Western World* (Santa Fe: Clear Light Books, 1999), 3.

[3] Ibid., 4

[4] Ibid., 4

[5] Ibid., 1

[6] Ibid., 10-13

[7] Ibid., 10-13

genocide characteristic of "utopian ideologies."[8] The racialized tyranny and religious persecution promoted under Hitler's "Third Reich" and American Christianity's "Kingdom of God" set the stage for Jewish and Indian liquidation by devaluing Jewish and Indian lives in light of the "pursuit of the ideal." Furthermore, the "pursuit of utopia," the "pursuit of the ideal," has

> Provided a stream of rationalization that justified plunder, racism and oppression in the name of a better future. The fact that conquests and their reward were acceptable and continue to be celebrated in Western history is key to the story of how the world came to be the way it is.[9]

Mohawk proposes a delicate balance between Jew and Indian, American and German, religion and utopian, white supremacy and anti-Indian racism. The overlap between Jews and Native Americans has resulted from a shared subjection to "utopian" or "futuristic" social movements steeped in a pursuit of the greater good.[10] Anti-Indian racism and anti-Semitism, used to justify and rationalize the liquidation of the Indians of America and the Jews of Europe, were birthed from analogous "utopian ideologies" that are a significant undercurrent of the D.N.A. of Euro-American history. Contemporary anti-Indian racism in America and the steady stream of anti-Semitism in contemporary Europe suggest how dangerously ingrained "utopian ideologies" have become in Western society and how difficult they are to eliminate. Mohawk incorporates Jews, Natives, Nazi Germany, and colonial America to understand the horrors of history with the hope of advancing the moral agenda of all humanity; Mohawk's agenda is not to transfer moral or political authority from one subaltern group to another. Ultimately thinking in terms of "utopian movements" provides an advanced framework for investigating the historical similarities between Jewish and Native American communities as well as the consanguinity between American Jewish and American Indian communities. In this equation white supremacy arises as a "utopian legacy" intimately tied to the violent erasure of onkwehon:we in America and Jewish people in Europe.

2) What specific authors and artists, texts and media, do you rely on to engage students, faculty, and staff with the intersections between white supremacy, (anti-Indian) racism, and settler colonialism?

I teach a plethora of courses on regular rotation at SUNY Oswego that engage students in Native American history and culture, including but not limited to, NAS100: Introduction to Native American Studies, NAS330: Native Religion and Philosophy, NAS340: Native American Women, ANT356: History of the Haudenosaunee, and ANT357: Culture of the Haudenosaunee, ANT375: North American Indians but the course which focuses the most on settler colonialism is NAS350: Contemporary Native America. In this section I will discuss how contemporary Native scholars Laura Harjo (Mvskoke - geographer), Audra Simpson (Mohawk - anthropologist), and Nick Estes (Lakota - americanist) have utilized the category of settler colonialism to illuminate the relationships between colonizer and colonized; Indigenous and settler; gift and profit; land and loss.

For Audra Simpson the main venues of settler colonialism are sovereignty, land dispossession, extermination, and disappearance. According to Simpson,

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[8] Ibid., 5

[9] Ibid., 14

[10] Ibid., 2

> Under the conditions of settler-colonialism multiple sovereignties cannot proliferate robustly or equally.[11]
>
> Colonialism survives in a settler form. In this form, it fails at what it is supposed to do: eliminate Indigenous people; take all their land; absorb them into a white, property-owning body politic.[12]
>
> Settler colonialism is defined by a territorial project (the accumulation of land) whose seemingly singular focus differentiates it from other forms of colonialism…it is not labor but territory that it seeks.[13]
>
> Settler colonialism structures justice and injustice in particular ways, not through the conferral of recognition of the enslaved but by the conferral of disappearance in subject.[14]

In the above passages Simpson ties the success and failure of settler colonial structures to their ability to 1) interrupt Indigenous sovereignties, 2) eliminate Indigenous people in order to take all their land, 3) disappear Indigenous people (particularly women) from the land by any means necessary. Ultimately, for Simpson, settler colonialism is defined by the accumulation of land and the disproportionate suffering of Indigenous women. It is a form of colonialism defined by territorial expansion not one defined by economic exploitation and/or enslavement and it "requires Indigenous elimination for territory".[15] Throughout the chapters of *Mohawk Interruptus* Simpson argues that the experiences of Mohawk community at Kahnawa:ke and Akwesasne surrounding the creation of the St. Lawrence Seaway and the Mohawk community at Kanehsata:ke surrounding land expropriation (extension of Oka golf course) provide evidence for her claims that the structure of settler colonialism in Canada reflects its "desire for land, its propensity to consume, and its indifference to life."[16]

To compliment Simpson, I use the work of historian Laurence Hauptman to illustrate instances of Haudenosaunee land dispossession and the legal dimensions of/justifications for settler colonialism in the United States in the 20th century – specifically the Tuscarora Reservoir, Kinzua Dam, Oneida Land Claims, and Onondaga Lake. In recent years I have also been using the film "Remembering the Removal: Kinzua Dam and Forced Seneca Relocation by documentarian Caleb Abrams.[17] The film does a masterful job of applying Simpson's four attributes of settler colonialism (sovereignty, land dispossession, extermination, and disappearance) to the Seneca communities of Western New York and their fight against the creation of the Kinzua Dam - aka Allegheny Reservoir aka Lake Perfidy. According to Hauptman "throughout the tragedy, the army lacked sensitivity to Seneca mores and were often callous and intransigent in negotiating with the Indians, they bulldozed sacred sites, disturbed burials, and refused every alternative about the relocation of a separate Cornplanter

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[11] Audra Simpson: *Mohawk Interrupts: Political Life Across the Borders of Settler States* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2014), 12.

[12] Ibid., 7-8

[13] Ibid., 19

[14] Ibid., 23

[15] Ibid., 160

[16] Ibid., 147

[17] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=O4f3L2NScX0&t=96s

cemetery."[18] These elements of settler colonialism combined with imaginative Federal Indian Policy (Doctrine of Plenary Power and Eminent Domain) provided the justifications for Congress to "unilaterally sever treaty agreements and seize Indian lands."[19] It is clear that in the case of the Haudenosaunee (in both the U.S. and Canada in the 20th century) that settler colonialism is directly related to both land dispossession and termination of Federal responsibilities to Native American Nations as laid out in previous treaty arrangements – 1794 Treaty of Canandaigua, 1795 Jay Treaty, 1768/1784 Treaty of Fort Stanwix, 1797 Treaty of Big Tree.

A recent book that I have been using in NAS350 is Laura Harjo's *Spiral to the Stars: Mvskoke Tools of Futurity*. Harjo, a geographer by trade, embeds her work in the past, present, and futurity of the Mvskoke Nation. According to Harjo

> Many of the shifts in Mvskoke communities, and their reemergence in different iterations, are responses to settler colonialism. Settler colonialism is not a temporality that has passed; it is a far-reaching structure that persists. The logic of settler colonialism shapes how both nation-state and tribal governance function; it changes how we imagine the ways in which our families and romantic relationships operate and should be structured. Settler colonialism shapes our ways of knowing, managing, and exchanging land. Settler colonial structuring of land and laws renders Indigenous girls and women subhuman and rapeable with impunity, as exemplified by the ongoing issue of missing and murdered Indigenous women (#MMIW). Its institutions, laws, and practices work slowly and insidiously eliminate Indigenous people and other groups that are not white and heteronormative. Settler colonialism has a far-reaching impact, and it operates as expansive dispossession. Further, it works to dispossess Indigenous communities of their futures – futures imagined on their terms within their ways of knowing.[20]

In the above passage Harjo outlines at least eight different dimensions of settler colonialism: 1) changes in Native American communities are often times responses to settler colonialism, 2) the structure of settler colonialism has far reaching impacts on Native American communities, 3) settler colonialism is a key feature of modern American society shaping both nation-state and tribal governance, 4) settler colonialism influences our families and romantic relationships, 5) "settler colonialism shapes our ways of knowing, managing, and exchanging land", 6) laws of settler colonialism systems define Indigenous women and girls as subhuman and rapeable, 7) settler colonialism is based on expansive land dispossession, and 8) if left unchecked settler colonialism will rob Native American communities of both their present knowledge and ways of knowing in the future.

Like Simpson, Harjo narrows in on the relationship between sovereignty, land dispossession, and violence (rape, murder, disappearance) against Native American women. In recent years the #MMIW, #IdleNoMore, and #NoMoreStolenSisters movements have amplified the fact that Native women's bodies have been the site of conquest and colonization for the last 500 years – from Columbus up to today. Violence against Native women has reached epidemic status inside of Indian country. According to former Secretary of the Interior Deb Haaland

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[18] Laurence Hauptman: *The Iroquois Struggle for Survival: World War II to Red Power* (Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 1986), 91.

[19] Ibid., 98

[20] Laura Harjo: *Spiral to the Stars: Mvskoke Tools of Futurity* (Tucson: University of Arizona Press, 2019), 10.

"violence against Indigenous peoples is a crisis that has been underfunded for decades. Far too often murders and missing persons cases in Indian countries go unsolved and unaddressed, leaving families and communities devastated."[21] Inside Indian country May 5th has become "Red Dress Day" where folks will wear red to bring attention to Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women, Girls, and Two-Spirit peoples. The Red Dress Project is a series of art installations centering on the gendered and racialized nature of violent crimes against aboriginal women. The public display of Red Dresses is meant to evoke presence through the marking of absence. In the weeks leading up to May 5th, 2024, SUNY Oswego participated (for the first time) in the Red Dress Project by displaying 13 Red Dresses, created by students in the Costume and Design Department. This was a collaborative event between Artswego, Native American Studies, Criminal Justice, and Costume and Design. Two of the dresses were even sewn by dozens of student volunteers (many of whom had never hand sewn or used a sewing machine) who simply stopped by our tabling effort and wanted to learn about the National Day of Awareness for Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women and Girls. The dresses were beautiful and haunting, somber and stunning and caught the eye and attention of each and every person who walked past them. Campus art installations are one way of raising awareness about settler colonialism, white supremacy, and anti-Indian racism amongst all University students, faculty, and staff.

Nick Estes, Sichangu-Lakota and member of the Lower Brule Sioux Tribe, has written perhaps the most comprehensive historical and first-hand account of the Dakota Access Pipeline protests on the Standing Rock Reservation. Throughout the pages of *Our History is the Future: Standing Rock Versus the Dakota Access Pipeline, and the Long Tradition of Indigenous Resistance* Estes places the #NoDAPL protests in the long tradition of Indigenous resistance; however, according to Estes "we have to look further into the past: to the land, the water, and its people the Oceti Sakowin."[22] Like Simpson's Mohawk Interruptus Este's Our History is the Future spends an inordinate amount of time discussing the intersections between land dispossession, water, and settler colonialism. Also, like Simpson Estes is quick to point out how Anthropology's role in settler colonialism has resulted in heightened violence against Indigenous women. According to Estes, settler colonialism is bolstered by both educational systems (University values) and economic systems (Capitalist values). Estes called anthropology,

> A discipline that has robbed us of a viable future by trapping us in a past that never existed. In the last two centuries, armies of anthropologists, historians, archeologists, hobbyists, and grave robbers have pillaged and looted Indigenous bodies, knowledges, and histories, in the same way that Indigenous lands and resources were pillaged and looted. Their distorted, misinterpreted Indigenous histories are both irrelevant and unfamiliar to actually existing Indigenous peoples, and they are deeply disempowering.[23]
>
> Capitalism arose under a racist European feudal system. It used "race" as a form of rule—to subordinate, to kill, and to enslave others—and used that difference for profit-

[21] https://www.doi.gov/news/secretary-haaland-creates-new-missing-murdered-unit-pursue-justice-missing-or-murdered-american

[22] Nick Estes: *Our History is the Future: Standing Rock Versus the Dakota Access Pipeline, and the Long Tradition of Indigenous Resistance* (New York: Verso, 2023), 65.

[23] Ibid., 16

> making. Racial capitalism was exported globally as imperialism, including to North America in the form of settler colonialism.[24]

In the above passages Estes links the settler colonial dimensions of the American academy to the settler colonial dimensions of American economics. Working hand in hand (and as an extension of U.S. Federal government) American academics have played an oversized role in pillaging and looting "Indigenous bodies, knowledges, and histories" while simultaneously creating a vast body of knowledge (books, articles, documentaries, syllabi, lectures, workshops, etc.) that has trapped Indigenous communities in a "past that never existed" resulting in distortion, misinterpretation, and disempowerment. Therefore, Native American and Indigenous Studies emerges in part as a critique of the theories and methods of Anthropology and Archaeology. As the Director of Native American Studies, a minor which is nestled inside the Department of Anthropology, and an Assistant Professor of Anthropology I must prepare my students to understand the insidious elements of settler colonialism and appreciate Anthropology's role in promoting the educational dimensions of settler colonialism in classrooms, museums, literature, and governmental policies.

Before moving onto the last section of this essay I want to discuss the power of Jim Denomie's (Ojibwe) art for teaching and learning about settler colonialism. I use Denomie's paintings in nearly all of my courses. In NAS100 Denomie's masterpiece "Eminent Domain: A Brief History of America" is featured prominently on the front page of the syllabus and I tell students on the first day of class that by the end of our fifteen weeks together I hope that they can explain to me the meaning(s) behind the piece. As the semester wears on, I get more and more questions about "Eminent Domain" as students slowly realize how brilliantly detailed the painting is and how much Native American history and culture is depicted in one painting. Additionally, In NAS100 I also use Denomie's paintings "Non-Negotiable" when discussing removal, "Off the Reservation" when discussing reservation, treaty making, and the Dakota 38 and his piece "First Communion" when discussing the physical and sexual abuse that was commonplace throughout the Christian Residential School System. It really is true that,

> The temporality of Denomie's paintings push back against what scholars refer to as "Eurochronology" or "settler time," an understanding of time invested in a linear, progressive unfolding that has been thoroughly naturalized.[25]

Furthermore, in NAS350 Denomie's "Standing Rock" is featured prominently on the front page of the syllabus and for the final essay in that class I use Denomie's paintings "Dog Day Afternoon", "Wounded Knee", and "Standing-Rock Protectors". For this assignment I ask students to choose one of the aforementioned Denomie paintings and analyze the piece through the lens of Nick Estes. This essay assignment forces students to apply what they have learned about the Oceti Sakowin Oyate, the #NoDAPL water protectors, and Native American Sovereignty to unpack the images, color contrasts, themes, styles, rhythms, motivations, intents, and symbols displayed in Denomie's work. The saying "a picture says 1000 words" really doesn't do justice to the awesomeness of Jim Denomie's artwork and depending on predispositions some students might learn better through art (music, painting, sculpture, ceramics, pottery, poetry) then they do through modified Socratic lectures – my preferred method of classroom instruction. I have found the lyrical artwork of Jim Denomie to be an

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[24] Ibid., 28

[25] Nicole Soukup: *The Lyrical Artwork of Jim Denomie* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2023), 53.

invaluable asset in teaching my students about the intersections between settler colonialism, white supremacy, and anti-Indian racism. According to Soukup,

> Denomie's dedication to addressing systemic racism and the intertwined struggles of Native Americans in his work enabled him to see the bigger picture and historical threads in the #NoDAPL movement. Standing Rock 2016 and the paintings its related series are prayers honoring the resistance of the Oceti Sakowin against ongoing settler aggressions. The design of and imagery in Denomie's large painting shows that he understood that Standing Rock was not a single-issue event, but part of a historical continuum rejecting colonial violence and further incursions on Native sovereignty.[26]

Conclusion: The "O" in Onondaga

3) Have you ever caught yourself internalizing or reproducing white supremacy in your teaching? Sometimes internalizing white supremacy isn't about action it's about inaction. That class discussion/lecture when you didn't speak up (because you didn't know what to say or how to say it), the one team you still root for that has an Indian mascot (because they are special), or the years you spent driving on roads and past buildings that were inappropriately named and kept quiet (for fear of exposing yourself). My colleagues and I live and work in the shadow of the Onondaga Nation, the "people of the hills," who are part of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy or "People of the Longhouse". In fact, the entirety of the State University of New York (SUNY) at Oswego's 696-acre campus is located on the ancestral territory of the Onondaga Nation. Not surprisingly on the campus of SUNY Oswego sits four giant monuments to white supremacy or celebrations to white supremacy – Onondaga Hall, Oneida Hall, Seneca Hall, and Cayuga Hall. Additionally, "Iroquois Trail Road"[27] and "Onondaga Field" round out the Haudenosaunee themed names on our campus. After driving on those roads and past those fields and around those residence halls for four years I could no longer ignore these celebrations of settler colonialism. After extended conversations with my accomplices at Onondaga (dating back to 2019) during academic year 23-24 I formed and co-chaired a university taskforce to study the history and contemporary significance of Haudenosaunee names on the campus of SUNY Oswego.

The taskforce consisted of a broad spectrum of positionalities and opinions regarding documenting, interpreting, and commemorating Haudenosaunee communities. Following faculty assembly's approved charges from Spring 2023 the full taskforce met eight times between May 2023 and March 2024 with additional sub-committee (research, event planning, education, and community engagement) meetings and campus-based community outreach events. Each sub-committee was comprised of volunteers from within the taskforce based on their individual qualifications, availabilities, and unique skill sets. Throughout AY 2023-24, the taskforce conducted archival research, planned one open campus lecture for

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[26] Ibid., 66.

[27] "Iroquois" is both culturally and historically incorrect. Between French, Algonkin (Huron), and English (British) the etymology is unknown; however, "Iroquois" roughly translates as "snake", "snake in the grass", or "the snake people" and was pejoratively ascribed to Haudenosaunee peoples by their enemies and territorial adversaries. "Iroquois" people call themselves "Haudenosaunee" or People of the Longhouse – a confederacy made up of six unique and distinct Nations: the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, Seneca, and Tuscarora that came together approximately 1,000 years ago. Linguists and anthropologists alike would classify "Haudenosaunee" as the emic term or one that originated from within the community. "Iroquois", the etic term, is one that has been applied from outside the group. "Iroquois" once dominated the academy but has now been replaced by "Haudenosaunee" as the respectful recognition of the autonomy and sovereignty of the Confederacy.

Columbus/Indigenous Peoples' Day featuring Oswego faculty, a student, and Shawna Booth (Onondaga, Eel Clan and Big Picture Program Home School Liaison), two educational workshops ("Thanksgiving Teach-In" led by Adolescence Social Studies Education Teacher Candidates from the Department of Curriculum/Instruction and "Cornhusk Doll Legend and Workshop" with Chelsea Jocko from the Oneida Nation hosted by Native American Studies), and one movie night (BEANS by Tracey Deer hosted by the office of the Dean of CLAS) all designed for students and open to the larger Oswego community. Additionally, the taskforce sought advisement by local Nation Chiefs and Clanmothers, participated in scholarly conference presentations, collaborated on the creation of an art installation focusing on May 5th, Red Dress Day, and #MMIW (partnership between NAS, Criminal Justice, Costume and Design, and Artswego), and hosted documentary screenings (Ohero:kon – Under the Husk featuring Q+A with Director Katsitsionni Fox hosted by Native American Studies) to explore Oswego's interest and infrastructural capacities for future initiatives.

After many months of fact finding, archival research, campus events, and collaborations with the Onondaga Nation the taskforce found that the residence halls, roads, and fields named after the Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and Seneca Nations provide zero educational value or programming concerning the historical, sociological, and/or contemporary significance of the Haudenosaunee to the students who reside, eat, walk, drive, and create community on SUNY Oswego's West Campus. Furthermore, the taskforce concluded that keeping these names is inconsistent with SUNY Oswego's mission, values, and ethos. The long and brutal history of settler colonialism, broken treaties, and land dispossession in New York State including, but not limited to, the Sullivan-Clinton Campaign, Ogden Land Company, residential school system, and creation of the St. Lawrence Seaway, Kinzua Dam, Tuscarora Reservoir, and the over pollution of Onondaga Lake run contrary to SUNY Oswego's Mission Statement of access, learning, equity, sustainability, and collaboration. For these reasons the taskforce recommended the removal and replacement of all Haudenosaunee themed names (residence halls, roads, and fields) from the campus of SUNY Oswego.

In addition to removing and replacing Haudenosaunee themed names the taskforce recommended 1) providing signs and signage that identifies the previous names of sites and reasons behind the renaming decision; 2) permanently hoisting the Haudenosaunee flag to a flagpole in front of Culkin Hall (main administrative building) and arena; 3) constructing a permanent art installation on campus to recognize the historical and sociological significance of the Haudenosaunee; 4) offering permanent educational opportunities that center Indigenous voices on campus (Orange Shirt Day, Indigenous Peoples' Day, Native American Heritage Month, Maple Sap season, Red Dress Day, etc.) ; 5) prioritizing scholarship opportunities for Haudenosaunee students; 6) hosting a renaming celebration; 7) creation of publication of campus, its history, the history of the region, the history of Haudenosaunee confederacy including renaming and future in order to ensure that the legacies of the Haudenosaunee was not erased from the history of SUNY Oswego.

The process of decolonization is long and slow. It involves forging new relationships of exchange and collaboration with contemporary Haudenosaunee communities along with changing the hearts and minds of folks entrenched in systems of domination and subjugation. Before we are ready to change the names of the aforementioned buildings, roads, and fields we must rethink the values of the University system. In his most recent book, *The Urgency of Indigenous Values*, Philip Arnold argues that only a collaborative model of scholarship could "Indigenize the university itself" since the "inclusion of Indigenous Peoples as collaborators" would "fundamentally shift the nature of the university as a center for the production of

knowledge."[28] The recommendations of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy Naming Taskforce will not indigenize the academy; however, they are a recognition of past harms done, a gesture of goodwill (peace, friendship, respect), and an attempt to reframe relationships between SUNY Oswego and the Onondaga Nation. Each of the participants on this panel (myself, Terrian Garvis, Dr. Hurtado, Dr. Radhakrishnan, and Dr. Duran) played a pivotal role in the construction of the taskforce's findings, recommendations, and the timely completion of the taskforce. It should come as no surprise that each of these scholars also played a pivotal role in the liveliness of our panel discussion. Although we come from different disciplines, have different libraries, and different pedagogical approaches each of us confronts the legacies white supremacy and settler colonialism in our scholarship, teaching, and leadership and we have learned to hold space for each other's joy and success while holding each other accountable for our pettiness and mistakes.

[28] Philip Arnold: *The Urgency of Indigenous Values* (Syracuse: Syracuse University Press, 2023). 24-29.